Rome Travel Guide

The Eternal City of emperors, art and pasta - Italy

Rome: Overview and History

Rome is the capital of Italy and lies on the River Tiber. According to legend it was founded in 753 BC by the twins Romulus and Remus, who were raised by a she-wolf. Rome is called the Eternal City because it has been an important city for nearly three thousand years.

Rome was the capital of the Roman Empire, which at its peak stretched from Britain to the Middle East. The Romans founded or ruled many cities in this guide series, including Londinium (London), Lutetia (Paris) and Barcino (Barcelona). In AD 330 the Emperor Constantine moved the capital to a new city called Constantinople, today's Istanbul.

Rome later became the centre of the Catholic Church. Vatican City, the smallest country in the world, is located inside Rome and is ruled by the Pope. During the Renaissance, artists such as Michelangelo and Raphael created masterpieces here.

Today Rome is a lively modern capital where ancient ruins, baroque fountains and busy cafes sit side by side. Its historic centre is a UNESCO World Heritage Site.

Rome: Top Attractions

The Colosseum is the largest amphitheatre ever built. It was completed in AD 80 and could hold about 50,000 spectators who came to watch gladiator fights. A combined ticket also gives entry to the Roman Forum, the centre of public life in ancient Rome, and the Palatine Hill, where emperors built their palaces.

The Pantheon was rebuilt by the Emperor Hadrian around AD 125. Its huge concrete dome, with an open hole called the oculus at the top, is still the largest unreinforced concrete dome in the world.

In Vatican City, St Peter's Basilica is one of the largest churches in the world, and its dome was designed by Michelangelo. The Vatican Museums lead to the Sistine Chapel, where Michelangelo painted the ceiling and The Last Judgment.

The Trevi Fountain is the most famous fountain in Rome. Tradition says that if you throw a coin over your shoulder into the fountain you will return to Rome. The Spanish Steps and the Piazza Navona, with Bernini's Fountain of the Four Rivers, are also must-see sights.

Rome: Neighborhoods and Food

Trastevere, across the Tiber, is a charming neighbourhood of cobbled lanes, ivy-covered buildings and family-run trattorias. Monti, near the Colosseum, is a trendy area with vintage shops and wine bars. Testaccio is known as the home of traditional Roman cooking and has a popular covered food market.

Roman cuisine is simple and delicious. The four classic Roman pasta dishes are carbonara (egg, pecorino cheese, guanciale and black pepper), cacio e pepe (cheese and pepper), amatriciana (tomato and guanciale) and gricia.

Street food favourites include suppli, fried rice balls with melted mozzarella inside, and pizza al taglio, rectangular pizza sold by weight. Gelato is eaten all year round; look for shops that store it in covered metal tins rather than bright, fluffy mountains.

Romans drink espresso standing at the bar, and cappuccino is usually only ordered in the morning. Dinner starts late, often after 8 pm. A small cover charge called 'coperto' is common in restaurants.

Rome: Getting Around and Practical Tips

Much of central Rome is best explored on foot. The Rome Metro has three lines, A, B and C, which are useful for reaching the Colosseum, the Vatican area and Termini, the main railway station. Buses and trams fill the gaps.

Rome's main airport is Fiumicino (Leonardo da Vinci Airport). The Leonardo Express train reaches Roma Termini in about 32 minutes. The smaller Ciampino Airport is used by low-cost airlines. Turkish Airlines connects Rome with Istanbul in about two and a half hours.

Fast Frecciarossa trains link Rome with Naples in about 1 hour 10 minutes, Florence in about 1 hour 30 minutes and Venice in under 4 hours. The currency in Rome is the euro (EUR).

The best time to visit Rome is in spring, April and May, or in autumn, September and October, when the weather is warm but not too hot. In August it is very hot and many Romans leave the city for the Ferragosto holiday. Cover your shoulders and knees when entering churches.

Rome: Sample Itinerary and Day Trips

Day 1: Visit the Colosseum, the Roman Forum and the Palatine Hill, then have dinner in Monti. Day 2: Spend the morning in the Vatican Museums, the Sistine Chapel and St Peter's Basilica, then cross the river to Trastevere for the evening.

Day 3: Walk from the Pantheon to Piazza Navona, the Trevi Fountain and the Spanish Steps, and enjoy gelato along the way.

Ostia Antica, the ancient port city of Rome, is a large archaeological site only about 30 minutes away by train from Piramide station. Tivoli is home to the Renaissance gardens of Villa d'Este and the ruins of Hadrian's Villa.

On a longer day trip, take the fast train to Naples and continue to Pompeii, the Roman town buried by the eruption of Mount Vesuvius in AD 79.